Editing: Patterns & Rhythm

# The Film Editor

Like other primary members of the collaborative filmmaking team, the editor on a movie works closely with the director. During the preproduction phase, they may discuss storyboards and other previsualization materials. During production, an editor may cut together rough versions of completed scenes to assist the director in determining if additional footage is needed.

Of course, most of the editor's contributions happen after shooting is completed. During postproduction, the director-editor relationship can take many forms. A select group of classical Hollywood directors, including John Ford and Alfred Hitchcock, so precisely planned each shot, juxtaposition, and sequence prior to shooting that they claimed their movies were essentially edited before the cameras even rolled.

Of course, the typical director-editor relationship falls somewhere in between those two extremes. Before the edit begins, the director and editor discuss each scene's story, tone, and narrative function. After reviewing the footage provided, the editor communicates observations regarding performance, emphasis, important dramatic moments, event structure and order, and other potential expressive opportunities. The editor shares each draft version of every scene with the director so they can discuss what works and what doesn't. The editor takes notes and continues working on progressive versions, getting and applying feedback until the project is completed. Although the director has the final say on all decisions, editors are known to feel very strongly about particular cuts.

**Dorothy Spencer**

Director John Ford said that he edited the movie in the camera; in other words, he carefully visualized beforehand how the movie would look and then shot footage that could only be edited according to his plan. He minimized choices to retain creative control and prevent the studio bosses from meddling with his edit. But editors such as Dorothy Spencer certainly helped to craft Ford's films in postproduction. She edited seventy-five Hollywood films, including two of Ford's masterpieces: *Stagecoach* (1939) and *My Darling Clementine* (1946). Her work on *Stagecoach* earned Spencer the first of her four Academy Award nominations for Best Film Editing.

In addition to the director, the editor works closely with a number of other collaborators during postproduction. Assistant editors function as media managers: importing, labeling, organizing, and archiving terabytes of digital video and sound files. Coeditors help draft scenes and sequences. The postproduction supervisor shepherds the project through picture editing, and the concurrent and subsequent steps required before the final digital export: scoring, sound design, sound mixing, visual effects, and color grading and correction. The many stages the edit goes through on its way to completion are collectively termed *workflow*.

Once the footage is prepared by the assistant editors, the editor begins work on a first-draft edit known as the *rough cut*. As part of this process, she may create multiple versions of the

same scene or sequence for purposes of comparison. Today's digital editing allows for this level of experimentation as opposed to the old physical process of splicing processed film stock, which restricted editors to only one edited assembly at a time. The creative freedom made possible by digital editing may account for the fact that contemporary movies run longer and contain more individual shots than do earlier films. A typical Hollywood movie made in the 1940s and 1950s runs approximately 110 minutes and is composed of about 1000 shots; today's movies typically run between 120 and 140 minutes and consist of 2000 to 3000 shots.

When director Woody Allen shot what would eventually become *Annie Hall* (1977), he intended the movie to be a self-deprecating satire of his alter-ego character, Alvy Singer. But, after exhaustively reviewing the film's extensive raw footage, editor Ralph Rosenblum discovered that the story of Alvy's relationship with the character of Annie Hall was far more compelling. As he explains in his memoir *When the Shooting Stops . . . the Cutting Begins*, Rosenblum sacrificed countless comically brilliant scenes (much to Allen's initial chagrin) and restructured many others to ultimately reveal the endearing romantic comedy that won Oscars for Best Picture, Best Director, and Best Actress.

**_Annie Hall_ (Woody Allen, 1977)**

Over the course of postproduction, the edit moves through successive versions working toward the *fine cut*. Throughout this process, the editor edits the footage (or *picture*), as well as the dialogue, which is typically the only sound recorded on set during production. She makes notes regarding potential sounds or score to be added later and may even insert temporary "scratch" sound to help inform editing decisions that rely on or influence the use

of sound. The rest of the sound is handled by the sound editor and the sound designer, who will coordinate with the editor and director as the cut progresses to determine, design, and record sounds and music for each scene. Ultimately, the editor submits the *picture lock* version, the final edit of the film footage. The picture and dialogue must be finalized before the rest of the creative team can add sounds, music, and visual effects, then color grade the images, and finally mix together the many separate tracks of accumulated sound.

Film editing has five primary functions:

- 1. Organize fragmented action and events.
- 2. Create meaning through juxtaposition.
- 3. Create spatial relationships between shots.
- 4. Create temporal relationships between shots.
- 5. Establish and control shot duration, pace, and rhythm.

None of these functions work autonomously. Like all things cinematic, fragmentation, juxtaposition, spatial and temporal connections, and pace and rhythm are all interconnected and interdependent.